Handoff Diagnostic

Purpose

Examine what happens between processes, functions, teams, or individuals. Make the interface visible so you can better understand where work, information, responsibility, authority, or decisions succeed - or break down.

What It Is

- A practitioner tool
- A structured set of questions and prompts
- A starting point for conversation, investigation, and improvement
- Industry-agnostic

What It Is Not

- A validated assessment
- A regulatory standard
- A maturity model
- A substitute for process mapping
- A root cause analysis method
- A scoring system

Diagnostic Lens

A. Start with the Handoff

A handoff occurs whenever work, information, material, responsibility, authority, or a decision crosses a boundary. Sometimes the more useful place to look is the space between the processes.

What is being handed off: _____

From whom: _____

To whom: _____

When: _____

What happens next: _____

GET BOTH PERSPECTIVES

Before diagnosing the problem, ask both sides to describe the handoff independently. If the descriptions differ, that difference may be useful evidence.

01 Transfer

What exactly crosses the boundary?

- Is it clear what is being transferred?
- Do both sides use the same definition of ready?
- Is anything routinely missing or ambiguous?

02 Mechanism

A good handoff can fail if the way it travels is unreliable.

- How does it actually occur?
- Can one part arrive without another?
- Is it visible, traceable, and confirmed?

03 Ownership

Handoffs can create gaps, overlaps, or ambiguity.

- Who owns it before and after?
- Do responsibility and authority transfer together?
- Who acts when the handoff fails?

04 Information

The work may transfer while needed information does not.

- What information must travel with it?
- Is context informal or tribal?
- Can complete be distinguished from incomplete?

Observations / Evidence

B. THE HANDOFF MAP

Make the boundary visible. A simple visual can help both sides describe the handoff consistently.

SENDING SIDE Team / Function / Person	HANDOFF → → → → → →	RECEIVING SIDE Team / Function / Person
What crosses the boundary?		**Mechanism / channel**
Trigger (what starts it?)		**Expected next activity**

C. DESCRIBE IT INDEPENDENTLY

Capture each side's view before comparing. Use brief, factual statements.

Sending side says...	Receiving side says...

CONTINUE THE DIAGNOSTIC LENS

05 EXPECTATIONS

Both sides may be performing correctly against different expectations.

- What does each side expect the other to do?
- Are timing, completeness, and priority expectations shared?
- What does success mean to each side?

06 TIMING

Many handoff failures are failures of synchronization.

- When is it expected and when is it due?
- What triggers it?
- What happens early, late, or urgently?

07 ACCEPTANCE

Sending does not necessarily mean successfully handed off.

- How is receipt known?
- What determines acceptance or rejection?
- Is the receiver actually ready to act?

08 EXCEPTIONS

The normal path may work while the exception path does not.

- What happens when incomplete or rejected?
- Who resolves disagreement?
- Do exceptions create workarounds?

09 FEEDBACK

A system cannot improve if information travels only one way.

- Does the sender know whether it worked?
- Can feedback reach someone who can change upstream work?
- Are recurring patterns visible?

SYNTHESIZE

1. Where do the views agree?
2. Where do they differ?
3. What assumptions became visible?
4. What deserves deeper investigation?
5. What evidence would test that?
6. What should we not assume yet?

OPEN LAB NOTE: What question was missing? What didn't fit? What would you change? What did this help you see?

Use it. Challenge it. Change it. Make it better. Share what you learned.

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